The End of An Epoch

This work opened with a number of research questions, not least of which was why the Indian government's opinions were ignored when it came to formulating Britain's foreign policy in South Asia in the years after the First World War. Why was it that, even though relations with Persia and Afghanistan were intimately related with the security of India, Delhi's point of view was marginalised? Why was it not recognised that perhaps officials in India might be better placed than those in London to understand the problems facing Britain's imperial position in this region of the world? As noted in the Introduction, the answer to this hinges on the issue of who was formulating Britain's foreign policy in this period. Montagu summarised the situation himself in 1919 in a letter to Chelmsford. In response to the viceroy's complaints about being ignored, Montagu explained: 'it so happens that you are interested in matters in which...Lord Curzon plays a very important part. That is really the whole secret .' [1] As we have seen, despite what some authors have said, the Foreign Office still dominated the formulation of Britain's foreign policy in the post-1918 period. As foreign secretary, this meant Curzon would always have a large amount of control over Britain's foreign relations – with his experiences in South Asia and his personality traits, Curzon in fact came to dominate Anglo-Asian affairs. Unfortunately, this meant that in the years after 1918 the Indian government faced a formidable obstacle to having its voice heard in London. Curzon had a certain way of viewing the world, and the fact that the Indian government disagreed with this view meant it was destined to be ignored by the stubborn foreign secretary.

As for what influenced Curzon's thinking, the answer is relatively simple. The foreign secretary was an old-fashioned imperialist who believed that the prestige of the British Empire was best protected by maintaining a physical dominance over India's neighbouring states, thereby creating a buffer against Russia – for in Curzon's opinion Russia was always the premier enemy of the empire. This was the Great Game mentality described in Chapter One – a mode of thought which continually viewed Russia with